

English Ladder

Student Workbook

Understanding Events & Tenses in English

A polished self-study handout designed for print or tablet use. Read the concept, notice the pattern, and then complete the matching practice set on your own.



Grammar Concepts #14

Key Points

Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **Understanding Events & Tenses in English** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept #14 ► **Events & Tenses**

Here are a few examples of ways to talk about two events from different temporal (time) perspectives.

 2018 Martin marries	• Martin graduated <u>5 years prior to</u> marrying.
	• Martin married <u>5 years after</u> he graduated.
	• Martin married <u>3 years ago</u> and graduated <u>8 years ago</u> .
 2013 Martin graduates	• Martin will marry <u>5 years after</u> his graduation.
	• Martin graduated <u>5 years before</u> he plans to marry.
	• Martin graduated <u>3 years ago</u> . He'll marry <u>2 years from now</u> . It has been <u>3 years since</u> Martin's graduation. <u>Two years from now</u> , Martin will marry.
 2010	• Martin will graduate <u>5 years before</u> he marries.
	• Martin will marry <u>5 years after</u> he graduates.
	• Martin will graduate <u>in 2 years</u> and marry <u>7 years from now</u> .
2008	

Remember that if the reference point is now, we use **ago** and **from now/in**. For other times we use **before/prior to** and **after**.

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Core Idea

In English, expressing events in relation to one another in time can be challenging, especially for non-native speakers. This guide will help you understand how to talk about two events from different temporal (time) perspectives, using examples from the image provided.

Quick reference

Past Events	Martin graduated 5 years prior to marrying. Explanation: Martin's graduation happened 5 years before his marriage. Similar Example: Maria learned Spanish 3 years prior to moving to Spain.
Future Events	Martin will marry 5 years after his graduation. Explanation: Martin's marriage will occur 5 years after he graduates. Similar Example: Sarah will travel to Japan 1 year after she gets her passport.
Combining Past and Future Events	Martin will graduate 5 years before he marries. Explanation: Martin's graduation will occur 5 years before his future marriage. Similar Example: Lucy will finish her book 2 years before it gets published.
Key Points to Remember	Ago: Used for events that happened before the current time (e.g., "3 years ago").

Key Points

Past Events

When discussing events that have already occurred, we often use terms like ago, before, after, and since. Here are some examples:

- Martin graduated 5 years prior to marrying. Explanation: Martin's graduation happened 5 years before his marriage. Similar Example: Maria learned Spanish 3 years prior to moving to Spain.
- Martin married 5 years after he graduated. Explanation: Martin's marriage occurred 5 years after his graduation. Similar Example: Alex started his business 2 years after finishing college.
- Martin married 3 years ago and graduated 8 years ago. Explanation: Martin's marriage happened 3 years ago from now, and his graduation happened 8 years ago from now. Similar Example: Julia visited Paris 2 years ago and graduated from university 5 years ago.

Future Events

When talking about events that will happen in the future, we use terms like in, before, after, and from now. Here are some examples:



- Martin will marry 5 years after his graduation. Explanation: Martin's marriage will occur 5 years after he graduates. Similar Example: Sarah will travel to Japan 1 year after she gets her passport.
- Martin graduated 5 years before he plans to marry. Explanation: Martin's graduation occurred 5 years before the future point of his marriage. Similar Example: David bought a house 2 years before he plans to retire.
- Martin graduated 3 years ago. He'll marry 2 years from now. Explanation: Martin's graduation happened 3 years ago from now, and he plans to marry 2 years in the future from now. Similar Example: Emily started her job 4 years ago. She plans to start her own business 3 years from now.
- It has been 3 years since Martin's graduation. Explanation: 3 years have passed since Martin graduated. Similar Example: It has been 6 months since Anna moved to New York.
- Two years from now, Martin will marry. Explanation: Martin's marriage will happen 2 years from the current time. Similar Example: Two weeks from now, I will start my new job.

Combining Past and Future Events

When combining both past and future events, understanding the relationship between different points in time is crucial. Here are some examples:

- Martin will graduate 5 years before he marries. Explanation: Martin's graduation will occur 5 years before his future marriage. Similar Example: Lucy will finish her book 2 years before it gets published.
- Martin will marry 5 years after he graduates. Explanation: Martin's marriage will happen 5 years after his graduation. Similar Example: John will travel to Europe 1 year after he completes his degree.
- Martin will graduate in 2 years and marry 7 years from now. Explanation: Martin's graduation is set to happen in 2 years from now, and his marriage is planned for 7 years from now. Similar Example: Lisa will finish her training in 6 months and start her own practice 1 year from now.

Key Points to Remember

- Ago: Used for events that happened before the current time (e.g., "3 years ago").
- Before/Prior to: Used for events that occurred earlier in relation to another event (e.g., "5 years before he plans to marry").
- After: Used for events that occurred later in relation to another event (e.g., "5 years after he graduated").
- Since: Used to measure the time from a past event to the present (e.g., "3 years since Martin's graduation").
- From now/In: Used to indicate the time from the present moment to a future event (e.g., "2 years from now").

By understanding and practicing these concepts, you can accurately describe the timing of events in relation to one another, making your English communication more precise and clear.



Practice Check

Answer the quiz questions below with responses consistent with the grammar concepts taught on the left.

ITEM 01

Maria learned Spanish 3 years _____ to moving to Spain.

Answer: _____

ITEM 02

Alex started his business 2 years _____ finishing college.

Answer: _____

ITEM 03

Julia visited Paris 2 years _____ and graduated from university 5 years _____.

Answer: _____

ITEM 04

Sarah will travel to Japan 1 year _____ she gets her passport.

Answer: _____

ITEM 05

David bought a house 2 years _____ he plans to retire.

Answer: _____

**ITEM 06**

Emily started her job 4 years _____. She plans to start her own business 3 years _____ now.

Answer: _____

ITEM 07

It has been 6 months _____ Anna moved to New York.

Answer: _____

ITEM 08

Two weeks _____ now, I will start my new job.

Answer: _____

ITEM 09

Lucy will finish her book 2 years _____ it gets published.

Answer: _____

ITEM 10

John will travel to Europe 1 year _____ he completes his degree.

Answer: _____

ITEM 11

Lisa will finish her training in 6 months and start her own practice 1 year _____ now.

Answer: _____

**ITEM 12**

Martin will marry 5 years _____ his graduation.

Answer: _____

ITEM 13

Martin graduated 5 years _____ he plans to marry.

Answer: _____

ITEM 14

Martin graduated 3 years _____. He'll marry 2 years _____ now.

Answer: _____

ITEM 15

It has been 3 years _____ Martin's graduation.

Answer: _____

ITEM 16

Two years _____ now, Martin will marry.

Answer: _____

ITEM 17

Martin will graduate 5 years _____ he marries.

Answer: _____

**ITEM 18**

Martin will marry 5 years _____ he graduates.

Answer: _____

ITEM 19

Martin will graduate in 2 years and marry 7 years _____ now.

Answer: _____

ITEM 20

John graduated 3 years _____, and he will start his master's degree 2 years _____ now.

Answer: _____

ITEM 21

Alice will complete her project 6 months _____ now and present it 3 months _____ she finishes.

Answer: _____

ITEM 22

It has been 2 years _____ he last visited his hometown.

Answer: _____

ITEM 23

Tom will graduate in 1 year and start his job 2 years _____ now.

Answer: _____

**ITEM 24**

It has been 4 years _____ I moved to this city.

Answer: _____



Self-check Answer Key

Use the key after you have completed every item on your own.

Item 01 prior Explanation: "Prior to" means before a certain time or event. "Ago" is incorrect because it is used with a specific point in time in the past, not before another event. "Since" is incorrect because it is used to indicate the time from a past event to the present.

Item 02 after Explanation: "After" is used to indicate that one event happened following another. "Ago" is incorrect because it is used to specify how long before the present something happened. "Before" is incorrect because it would suggest the business was started before finishing college, which changes the meaning.

Item 03 ago, ago Explanation: "Ago" is used to indicate a time period that has passed from the present moment. "Before" and "after" are incorrect because they compare two events relative to each other, not relative to the present moment.

Item 04 after Explanation: "After" is correct to show that Sarah's travel happens following the event of getting her passport. "Ago" is incorrect because it refers to past time. "Before" is incorrect because it would mean she travels before getting her passport.

Item 05 before Explanation: "Before" indicates that the house purchase happened prior to his retirement. "After" is incorrect because it would mean he bought the house following his retirement. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed since a past event.

Item 06 ago, from Explanation: "Ago" indicates past time, while "from now" indicates future time from the present moment. "Before" and "after" do not fit because they do not indicate past or future relative to now.

Item 07 since Explanation: "Since" is used to indicate the time that has passed from a specific event until now. "Ago" is incorrect because it would mean 6 months before now, not since a specific event. "Before" is incorrect because it does not indicate ongoing time from a past event.

Item 08 from Explanation: "From now" is used to indicate future time measured from the present moment. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed since a past event.

Item 09 before Explanation: "Before" indicates that finishing the book happens prior to its publication. "After" is incorrect because it would mean she finishes the book following its publication. "Since" is incorrect because it indicates time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 10 after Explanation: "After" is used to show that the travel happens following the completion of his degree. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Before" is incorrect because it would mean he travels before completing his degree.

Item 11 from Explanation: "From now" indicates the future time measured from the present moment. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event



to the present.

Item 12 after Explanation: "After" indicates that the marriage happens following the graduation. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Before" is incorrect because it would mean he marries before graduating.

Item 13 before Explanation: "Before" shows that the graduation happened prior to the planned marriage. "After" is incorrect because it would mean he graduated following his marriage. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 14 ago, from Explanation: "Ago" indicates past time, while "from now" indicates future time measured from the present moment. "Before" and "after" do not fit because they do not indicate past or future relative to now.

Item 15 since Explanation: "Since" is used to indicate the time that has passed from a specific event until now. "Ago" is incorrect because it means a specific time before now, not ongoing time. "Before" is incorrect because it does not indicate ongoing time from a past event.

Item 16 from Explanation: "From now" is used to indicate future time measured from the present moment. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 17 before Explanation: "Before" indicates that the graduation happens prior to the marriage. "After" is incorrect because it would mean he graduates following his marriage. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 18 after Explanation: "After" indicates that the marriage happens following the graduation. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Before" is incorrect because it would mean he marries before graduating.

Item 19 from Explanation: "From now" is used to indicate future time measured from the present moment. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 20 ago, from Explanation: "Ago" is used to indicate a time period that has passed from the present moment. "From now" indicates future time measured from the present moment. "Before" and "after" do not fit because they do not indicate past or future relative to now.

Item 21 from, after Explanation: "From now" indicates future time measured from the present moment. "After" indicates that the presentation happens following the project completion. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Before" is incorrect in this context because it would change the sequence of events.

Item 22 since Explanation: "Since" is used to indicate the time that has passed from a specific event until now. "Ago" is incorrect because it means a specific time before now, not ongoing time. "Before" is incorrect because it does not indicate ongoing time from a past event.



Item 23 from Explanation: "From now" is used to indicate future time measured from the present moment. "Ago" is incorrect because it indicates past time. "Since" is incorrect because it refers to time passed from a past event to the present.

Item 24 since Explanation: "Since" is used to indicate the time that has passed from a specific event until now. "Ago" is incorrect because it means a specific time before now, not ongoing time. "Before" is incorrect because it does not indicate ongoing time from a past event.
